

Background

- Mainstream religions condemn premarital sexual activity, often arguing that it is harmful to emotional well-being.
- Self-esteem, a key component of well-being, is central to evaluating these claims.
- Mixed results in prior research about sexual behavior and self-esteem suggest this relationship may depend on other psychological or social factors.
- Religiosity has been shown to decrease premarital sexual behavior, but little research exists on how it affects the emotional consequences thereof.

Methods

Data

- This study uses data from Wave III of the National Longitudinal Study of Adolescent to Adult Health
- The analytical sample size consists of N=3,532 unmarried young adults ages 18–27

Measures

- Self-esteem was measured by averaging a set of 4 questions related to self-esteem
- Sexual behavior was measured as the number of partners with whom respondents report having penile-vaginal intercourse in the past 12 months
- Religiosity was measured with the question “How important is your religious faith to you?”

Analysis

- Linear regression was used to test the following hypotheses

H₁: Premarital sexual behavior is related to self-esteem

H₂: Religiosity moderates the association between premarital sexual behavior and self-esteem, such that the relationship is more negative among highly religious individuals

Results

The relationship between number of sexual partners in the past year and self-esteem was not significant

Table 1. Relationship between Past-year Sex Partners and Self-Esteem; Unstandardized Coefficients from Linear Regression	
	Unstandardized Coefficients
Number of vaginal intercourse partners in past 12 months	-.006
How important is your religious faith to you?	
Somewhat important	.040
Very important	.099**
More important than anything else	.170***
Age at time interviewed	-.011*
CES-Depression score	-.467***
R's personal income in dollars	.015
Male	-.011
How often R attended religious services in the past 12 months	
A few times	.015
Several times	-.011
Once a month	.054
2 or 3 times a month	.007
Once a week	.024
More than once a week	.026
R's political alignment	
Very Conservative	.141*
Conservative	.009
Liberal	-.016
Very Liberal	-.018
Doesn't know	-.066
Respondent race-ethnicity category	
Black	.137***
Hispanic	.092**
Asian	.040
Native American	.065
Constant	4.563***
N	3,532

Table 2.
Moderation of Relationship between Sex Partners and Self-Esteem by Religiosity;
Unstandardized Coefficients from Linear Regression with Interaction Terms

	Unstandardized Coefficients
Number of vaginal intercourse partners in past 12 months	-.011
How important is your religious faith to you?	
Somewhat important	.041
Very important	.085*
More important than anything else	.130**
Interaction: partners x religious importance	
Somewhat important	-.001
Very important	.008
More important than anything else	.026
Age at time interviewed	-.011*
CES-Depression score	-.467***
R's personal income in dollars	.000
Male	.006
How often R attended religious services in the past 12 months	
A few times	.015
Several times	-.010
Once a month	.056
2 or 3 times a month	.007
Once a week	.028
More than once a week	.037
R's political alignment	
Very Conservative	.143*
Conservative	.011
Liberal	-.016
Very Liberal	-.018
Doesn't know	-.066
Respondent race-ethnicity category	
Black	.135***
Hispanic	.092**
Asian	.041
Native American	.063
Constant	4.575***
N	3,532

Source: National Longitudinal Study of Adolescent to Adult Health, Wave III (2001–2002)

* p < .05; ** p < .01; *** p < .001.

Religious importance did not significantly moderate the relationship between sexual partners and self-esteem.

Conclusions

- The analyses did not provide support for either hypothesis.
- The absence of significant effects suggests that premarital sexual behavior may be less impactful on emotional well-being than often claimed, regardless of religiosity.

Limitations & Suggestions

- Further research should consider additional operationalizations
- Frequency of premarital sexual behavior rather than number of partners.
- Forms of sexual behavior other than penile-vaginal intercourse
- Other proxies for well-being, such as life satisfaction, stress, and loneliness
- Other measures of religiosity, such as frequency of attendance and engagement in religious activities other than worship services
- Notably, these data were gathered from 2001 to 2002. More recent data would improve generalizability
- Even if the relationship between premarital sexual behavior and well-being is statistically insignificant, potential individual-level effects warrant qualitative research.